

Japanese Izakaya

居酒屋 — The Complete Operator Blueprint

Recipes · Food Costs · Service Scripts · Weekly Prep · P&L Model
US Market Edition · 2025

18–24%

TARGET FOOD
COST

20

MENU ITEMS

\$45–65

AVG SPEND / HEAD

\$29.99

GUIDE PRICE

// CHEF'S LENS — JAPAN

"Japanese cuisine is built on a single untranslatable principle: shokunin kishitsu — the craftsman's spirit. It is the belief that any task, however small, deserves complete attention and relentless refinement. The izakaya cook who has grilled yakitori for twenty years has not been doing the same thing twenty times a year — he has been making incremental improvements twenty times a year. This guide is the map. The shokunin spirit is yours to cultivate."

1 ENTRÉES

Edamame — Salted Steamed Soybeans

Sea salt, sesame oil, togarashi option · Sell: \$5.99

5 min Entrée FC 8%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Frozen edamame (in pod)	180g	\$0.36
Sea salt (coarse, finishing)	3g	\$0.01
Sesame oil (light drizzle)	3ml	\$0.04
Togarashi (optional, on request)	1g	\$0.02
Total cost per serve		\$0.43
Cost per serve		\$0.43
Sell price		\$5.99
Food cost %		7.2%
Contribution margin		\$5.56

- 1 **Boil in heavily salted water:** The salted cooking water seasons the bean inside the pod — this is why proper edamame tastes different from unsalted boiled edamame. Bring water to a rolling boil with 1 tbsp salt per litre. Cook from frozen 4–5 minutes. The pods should be bright green and the beans inside tender but with a slight bite.
- 2 **Drain and season immediately:** Drain well — wet edamame dilutes the finishing salt. While still hot, toss with a tiny drizzle of sesame oil and a generous pinch of coarse sea salt. The heat of the beans warms the sesame oil and releases its aroma. Serve immediately — hot edamame is categorically better than warm or room-temperature edamame.
- 3 **The eating technique:** Edamame is eaten by squeezing the pod with your teeth — the beans pop into your mouth and the pod is discarded. Brief first-time guests: "Hold the pod and pull it through your teeth to release the beans." This small education prevents awkward attempts to eat the pod and creates an engaged, interactive start to the meal.
- 4 **Upsell togarashi:** Always offer at ordering: "Would you like them plain with sea salt, or with togarashi — Japanese seven-spice?" The choice creates engagement and the togarashi option adds \$0.02 cost with no price change. Most guests choose togarashi once they know it exists — it makes a simple dish feel considered.

Chef's Tip: Edamame at 7.2% food cost is your most profitable item per dollar of effort. It arrives at the table within 5 minutes of seating and immediately communicates that the kitchen is alive and attentive. Never skip this — it sets the pace and tone of the entire meal. Offer it automatically to every table on seating.

SOYA SESAME GLUTEN-FREE ✓ VEGAN ✓

Gyoza — Pan-Fried Pork Dumplings

6 pieces crispy-bottomed gyoza, ponzu dipping sauce · Sell: \$10.99

10 min

Entrée

FC 17%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 6 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Gyoza wrappers (round, thin)	6 wrappers	\$0.18
Pork mince (filling)	90g	\$0.45
Napa cabbage (salted, squeezed dry)	40g	\$0.06
Garlic, ginger, sesame oil, soy sauce, sake (filling season)	15g	\$0.14
Ponzu dipping sauce (batch)	40ml	\$0.10
Vegetable oil (frying)	10ml	\$0.02
Total cost per serve		\$0.95
Cost per serve		\$0.95
Sell price		\$10.99
Food cost %		8.6%
Contribution margin		\$10.04

- 1

Salt and squeeze the cabbage: Toss finely shredded napa cabbage with salt, rest 10 minutes, squeeze out all moisture aggressively. This step is critical — wet cabbage in the filling creates steam during cooking that prevents the crispy bottom from forming and makes the filling watery. The squeezed cabbage should be almost dry to the touch.
- 2

Mix filling with intention: Combine pork mince, squeezed cabbage, minced garlic, grated ginger, sesame oil, soy sauce, and sake. Mix vigorously with your hand in one direction for 2 minutes — this develops the protein and creates a cohesive, sticky filling that holds together during cooking. Under-mixed filling falls apart when bitten.
- 3

The yaki-mushi technique — fry then steam: Heat oil in a flat-based pan. Place gyoza flat-side down in a single layer. Fry 2 minutes until golden. Add 60ml water, cover immediately — the steam cooks the top of the dumpling while the bottom continues to crisp. Cook covered 3 minutes until water evaporates. Remove lid, fry 30 seconds more to re-crisp the bottom. This technique produces the characteristic crispy base with tender top.
- 4

Serve immediately, crispy side up: Flip gyoza onto the plate crispy-side up — the golden base is the visual centrepiece. Serve within 90 seconds of leaving the pan — the crispy bottom softens rapidly as steam escapes. The ponzu dipping sauce (citrus soy) provides acidity that cuts through the pork fat perfectly.

Chef's Tip: Gyoza at 8.6% food cost is your second-best margin item after edamame. Make the filling in large batches and freeze pre-formed gyoza on trays. Cook from frozen — add 2 minutes to the steam step. Having frozen gyoza ready eliminates prep pressure during service. Your best-selling entrée by volume.

GLUTEN (wrappers, soy)

SOYA

SESAME

Agedashi Tofu — Crispy Fried Tofu in Dashi

Silken tofu, light batter, hot dashi broth, grated daikon, bonito · Sell: \$9.99

10 min Entrée FC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Silken tofu (firm enough to handle)	150g	\$0.38
Potato starch (light coating)	15g	\$0.04
Dashi broth (batch — kombu + bonito)	120ml	\$0.28
Mirin, soy sauce, sake (tsuyu seasoning)	20ml	\$0.14
Grated daikon, sliced spring onion, bonito flakes	20g	\$0.16

Total cost per serve \$1.00

Cost per serve	\$1.00
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	10.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.99

- 1

Drain tofu thoroughly: Press silken tofu between paper towels with a light weight for 20 minutes. Excess moisture causes violent oil splatter when frying and prevents the starch coating from adhering. The tofu should be firm enough to handle without breaking — if it collapses, it was too wet or too soft a grade. Use medium-firm silken tofu, not extra-soft.
- 2

Potato starch, not flour: Coat tofu cubes in potato starch only — shake off excess. Potato starch creates a thinner, crisper, more translucent coating than wheat flour. It also absorbs the dashi broth slightly as it sits, creating the characteristic soft-on-the-outside texture of properly made agedashi tofu. Corn starch is an acceptable substitute; wheat flour is not.
- 3

Fry at 180°C / 356°F: Fry 2-3 minutes until the coating is pale gold and crispy. The tofu inside should still be cool and silky. Do not over-fry — dark brown agedashi tofu has lost its delicate texture. Drain on paper towel and transfer immediately to the serving bowl before the crust softens.
- 4

Hot dashi poured at the table: Pour the hot seasoned dashi (tsuyu) around the tofu at the table — not before. The guest watches the steam rise and the bonito flakes dance in the heat. This tableside pour is a sensory ritual — it communicates precision and care. Top with grated daikon and spring onion. The bonito flakes move in the heat as if alive — this is called odori (dancing) and is visually captivating.

***Chef's Tip:** Agedashi tofu is your most technically demanding entrée and your best vegetarian showpiece. The contrast of crispy exterior, silky interior, and umami-rich dashi broth is one of the most elegant flavour combinations in Japanese cuisine. Master the draining and frying technique — a perfectly made agedashi tofu will be remembered.*

SOYA (tofu, soy sauce) FISH (dashi, bonito) GLUTEN (soy sauce)

GLUTEN-FREE option: use tamari

Yakitori — Grilled Chicken Skewers

3 skewers chicken thigh, tare glaze or salt, charcoal grilled · Sell: \$10.99

12 min

Entrée

FC 16%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 3 SKEWERS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (skin on, cubed)	120g	\$0.85
Tare glaze (batch — soy, mirin, sake, sugar, reduced)	30ml	\$0.22
Bamboo skewers (soaked)	3	\$0.03
Charcoal fuel (per serve)	—	\$0.20
Sansho pepper or shichimi (finish)	0.5g	\$0.02
Lemon wedge	1 wedge	\$0.05
Total cost per serve		\$1.37
Cost per serve		\$1.37
Sell price		\$10.99
Food cost %		12.5%
Contribution margin		\$9.62

- 1**Skin-on thigh only — never breast:** Yakitori is built on chicken thigh with skin on. The skin renders over the charcoal, basting the meat in its own fat, and caramelises with the tare glaze to create an intensely flavourful, slightly crispy exterior. Chicken breast dries out in 4 minutes over charcoal. This substitution is not acceptable. Thigh is the correct cut — full stop.
- 2**The tare is a living sauce:** Tare glaze starts as a combination of soy sauce, mirin, sake, and sugar reduced to a thick syrup. It deepens and improves every time skewers are dipped into it during cooking — the dripping chicken fat and caramelised bits enrich the tare over weeks and months. Never discard your tare. Top it up. The tare at a 50-year-old yakitoriya is the accumulated flavour of 50 years.
- 3**Charcoal is non-negotiable:** Yakitori cooked on a gas grill is not yakitori. The binchotan charcoal (white oak charcoal) burns at a consistent, radiant heat without flame — it caramelises the tare and renders the chicken fat without burning. The smoke from fat dripping onto charcoal infuses the meat with a flavour that is completely irreproducible on gas. Invest in a proper yakitori grill and binchotan.
- 4**Tare application — multiple passes:** Begin grilling plain. After 3 minutes, dip the skewer in tare and return to the grill. Dip and grill 3-4 times total — each pass builds up a lacquered layer. The final pass is the most important — it creates the characteristic glossy, caramelised exterior. The salt option (shio) skips the tare and finishes with just sea salt and lemon — simpler, cleaner, equally traditional.

***Chef's Tip:** Yakitori is your highest-frequency reorder item — guests eat one round and immediately order another. Offer the tare and shio (salt) options for every skewer type. The variety of yakitori options across different cuts (negima, tsukune, sunagimo) can eventually become a dedicated yakitori menu. Start with thigh, master it, then expand.*

GLUTEN (soy sauce, mirin)

SOYA

Karaage — Japanese Fried Chicken

Double-fried chicken thigh, kewpie mayo, lemon, shredded cabbage · Sell: \$12.99

12 min Entrée FC 18%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, skin on, cubed)	160g	\$1.13
Marinade (soy sauce, sake, mirin, ginger, garlic)	40ml	\$0.22
Potato starch + plain flour (coating, 3:1)	30g	\$0.04
Kewpie mayonnaise	25g	\$0.18
Shredded cabbage (side)	40g	\$0.06
Lemon wedge	1	\$0.05
Frying oil	—	\$0.10

Total cost per serve \$1.78

Cost per serve	\$1.78
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	13.7%
Contribution margin	\$11.21

- 1

Marinade minimum 2 hours: Soy, sake, mirin, freshly grated ginger and garlic. The sake and mirin tenderise the chicken while the soy penetrates deeply — 2 hours produces good flavour, overnight is better. Pat the marinated chicken dry before coating — wet chicken makes the coating gummy instead of crispy. The drying step is as important as the marinade itself.
- 2

Potato starch and flour coating — 3:1 ratio: The potato starch creates the extraordinarily craggy, irregular surface that is the visual signature of karaage. Pure potato starch produces a very fragile crust; the small amount of flour provides structural support. Coat each piece generously, press the coating on, shake off excess. The irregular surface creates more surface area — more crunch per bite.
- 3

Double fry for maximum crunch: First fry at 160°C / 320°F for 3 minutes — low heat cooks the chicken through without browning the crust. Rest 3 minutes. Second fry at 190°C / 374°F for 90 seconds — high heat caramelises and crisps the surface aggressively. The resting period allows moisture to migrate to the surface, which then converts to steam in the second fry, creating internal expansion and a dramatically crunchier crust.
- 4

Kewpie mayo is non-negotiable: Kewpie is Japanese mayonnaise — made with only egg yolks (not whole eggs), rice vinegar, and MSG. It is richer, more umami, and more acidic than American mayonnaise. It is not interchangeable. Serve it in a squeeze bottle alongside the karaage — the guest squeezes it over or dips. The contrast of crispy chicken, rich kewpie, and acidic lemon is one of the great flavour combinations in comfort food globally.

Chef's Tip: Karaage is the dish that converts first-time izakaya guests into regulars. It is genuinely the best fried chicken in the world when made correctly. The double-fry technique and kewpie mayo together create an eating experience that no other culture's fried chicken replicates. Own this dish completely.

GLUTEN (soy, flour) SOYA EGGS (kewpie)

Tataki — Seared Beef with Ponzu

Seared beef sirloin, ponzu, grated daikon, crispy garlic, sesame · Sell: \$14.99

10 min

Entrée

FC 22%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef sirloin (whole piece, seared)	120g	\$2.32
Ponzu sauce (batch — yuzu, soy, mirin, dashi)	40ml	\$0.28
Grated daikon	30g	\$0.08
Crispy garlic slices (fried in oil)	5g	\$0.06
Toasted sesame seeds, spring onion, micro shiso	5g	\$0.12
Ice bath (for cooling after sear)	—	\$0.01
Total cost per serve		\$2.87
Cost per serve		\$2.87
Sell price		\$14.99
Food cost %		19.1%
Contribution margin		\$12.12

- 1

The tataki technique — sear and shock: Heat a cast iron pan until smoking. Sear the beef loin on all four long sides — 30 seconds per side. The entire process takes 2 minutes. Immediately plunge into an ice bath for 2 minutes — this stops the cooking process and chills the exterior while the interior remains raw. The result: a thin band of cooked meat on all surfaces, raw throughout the centre. This is the tataki method.
- 2

Slice thin and arrange: Remove from ice bath, pat dry, slice 4mm thin against the grain. Fan slices across the plate slightly overlapping — each slice showing the contrast of the dark seared exterior and the deep red raw interior. This visual cross-section is the tataki's signature presentation. The precision of the slicing communicates kitchen discipline immediately.
- 3

Ponzu is the dish's soul: Yuzu ponzu — citrus soy sauce with dashi — is light, acidic, and deeply savoury simultaneously. It does not overpower the beef; it frames it. Spoon or pour ponzu over the arranged slices at plating. The acid in the ponzu very slightly continues to "cook" the surface of the beef as it sits — serve immediately after plating.
- 4

Garnish with texture and aroma: Grated daikon alongside (piquant, cleansing), crispy garlic slices on top (crunch, depth), sesame seeds (nutty), spring onion (fresh), micro shiso if available (floral, anise). Each garnish serves a function — none are purely decorative. The finished plate should be visually beautiful and offer multiple flavour dimensions in a single bite.

***Chef's Tip:** Beef tataki is your most premium entrée and the one that communicates the kitchen's technical capability most clearly. The ice bath technique is simple but precise — and the result is genuinely impressive. Source good-quality sirloin: the seared exterior caramelises beautifully and the raw interior is the entire point. Do not overcook.*

GLUTEN (soy, ponzu)

SOYA

FISH (dashi in ponzu)

SESAME

2

MAIN DISHES

Tonkotsu Ramen — Pork Bone Broth Noodle

Rich white pork broth, chashu pork belly, soft egg, nori, menma · Sell: \$17.99

15 min

Main

FC 22%

INGREDIENTS (PER BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Tonkotsu broth (batch — 12hr pork bone)	400ml	\$1.10
Fresh ramen noodles (thin, straight)	130g	\$0.42
Chashu pork belly (batch braised)	80g	\$0.72
Soft-boiled ajitsuke tamago (marinated egg)	1 egg	\$0.45
Menma (bamboo shoots, seasoned)	30g	\$0.22
Nori sheet, spring onion, sesame, mayu (black garlic oil)	10g	\$0.15
Total cost per bowl		\$3.06
Cost per bowl		\$3.06
Sell price		\$17.99
Food cost %		17.0%
Contribution margin		\$14.93

- 1

The broth is your identity: Tonkotsu broth requires 12-18 hours of aggressive boiling of pork femur and trotters. The vigorous boil emulsifies the collagen and fat into the water — this is why tonkotsu is white and creamy, not clear. A gentle simmer will never produce the characteristic milky opacity. Begin your broth batch the afternoon before service. The bones must be blanched first (cold water to boil, discard water) to remove blood and impurities that would make the broth grey and bitter.
- 2

Chashu — the slow braise: Roll pork belly tight, tie with butcher's twine, sear all sides until deep brown. Braise in soy, mirin, sake, and water at

150°C / 302°F

 for 2.5 hours. Cool in the braising liquid overnight — the liquid becomes the chashu tare, used to season the broth. Slice cold for clean edges, torch or pan-sear each slice to order to caramelise the surface and warm through.
- 3

Ajitsuke tamago — the 6.5-minute egg: Boil eggs exactly 6 minutes 30 seconds from boiling water. Ice bath immediately for 5 minutes. Peel carefully — the white is set but the yolk is jammy, not liquid. Marinate peeled eggs in a 1:1 soy/mirin mixture diluted with water for minimum 4 hours. The eggs turn pale brown with a rich, savoury, slightly sweet flavour that complements the fatty broth perfectly.
- 4

Assembly speed is critical: Cook noodles in unsalted boiling water 90 seconds — rinse with cold water briefly to stop cooking, drain hard, place in warmed bowl. Ladle hot seasoned broth immediately — the hot broth finishes warming the noodles. Arrange chashu (2 slices, torched), halved egg, menma, nori upright at the side, spring onion, sesame, and a teaspoon of mayu (black garlic oil) in the centre. Total assembly: under 60 seconds.

***Chef's Tip:** Tonkotsu ramen sells itself — it is the single most-ordered Japanese dish in the US market. The broth batch is the investment; the assembly cost is low. Make broth twice weekly in large batches. Your ramen will develop its own personality over time as you adjust the seasoning and garnish. This is your anchor dish.*

GLUTEN (noodles, soy)

SOYA

EGGS

PORK

Chicken Katsu Curry — Breaded Chicken, Japanese Curry

Panko chicken breast, Japanese golden curry, steamed rice, fukujinzuke · Sell: \$17.99

15 min

Main

FC 20%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken breast (butterflied, 180g)	180g	\$1.00
Panko breadcrumbs + flour + egg (coating)	50g	\$0.18
Japanese curry sauce (batch — S&B or scratch)	200ml	\$0.85
Steamed Japanese short-grain rice	180g cooked	\$0.22
Fukujinzuke (pickled vegetable garnish)	20g	\$0.18
Frying oil	—	\$0.15
Total cost per serve		\$2.58
Cost per serve		\$2.58
Sell price		\$17.99
Food cost %		14.3%
Contribution margin		\$15.41

- 1

Japanese curry is not Indian curry: Japanese curry (karō) is sweeter, milder, and thicker — built on a roux base with fruit (apple, honey) and a proprietary spice blend that is distinctly Japanese. S&B Golden Curry blocks are the industry standard and are available at every Asian grocery at low cost. Scratch curry starts with the same concept: onion, carrot, potato, apple, spices, roux. The flavour profile is deeply comforting — it is Japan's most consumed home-cooked dish.
- 2

Panko is everything: Japanese panko breadcrumbs are larger, coarser, and lighter than European breadcrumbs — they create a dramatically crunchier, airier crust that absorbs less oil. Standard flour → egg wash → panko, pressed firmly. Fry at 175°C / 347°F for 4–5 minutes until deep golden. Rest 2 minutes on a rack — do not put on paper towel, which steams the underside and softens the crust. Slice on the bias into 5 strips before plating — this reveals the interior and allows the curry to pool between slices.
- 3

Curry presentation — the half-and-half plate: The classic katsu curry plating is rice on one side, curry poured over the other half, katsu slices bridging both. This visual allows the guest to control how much curry they eat with each bite. Fukujinzuke (sweet pickled mixed vegetables) provides acidity and colour contrast on the side — it is as traditional as the curry itself. Never skip it.
- 4

Offer topping upgrades: Cheese katsu curry (+\$2 — mozzarella melted over the katsu before serving), spicy katsu (+\$1 — red chilli added to curry), or vegetable katsu (aubergine and sweet potato, same technique, for vegetarians +\$0 cost save). These variations generate upsell revenue with minimal additional prep.

***Chef's Tip:** Katsu curry at 14.3% food cost is your best-margin main. It is also your most approachable dish for first-time Japanese food guests — it is comforting, familiar, and deeply satisfying. Build the curry in large batches; it improves overnight as the flavours meld. This dish will be a top-3 seller by volume.*

GLUTEN (panko, flour, curry roux) EGGS DAIRY (some curry blocks) SOYA

Salmon Teriyaki — Glazed Salmon Fillet

Pan-seared salmon, teriyaki glaze, steamed rice, pickled cucumber, sesame · Sell: \$19.99

12 min Main FC 24%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Salmon fillet (skin on, 180g portion)	180g	\$3.42
Teriyaki glaze (batch — soy, mirin, sake, sugar)	40ml	\$0.22
Steamed Japanese short-grain rice	180g cooked	\$0.22
Pickled cucumber (tsukemono, batch)	40g	\$0.12
Sesame seeds, spring onion, lemon	5g	\$0.08

Total cost per serve \$4.06

Cost per serve	\$4.06
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	20.3%
Contribution margin	\$15.93

- 1 Dry the skin completely:** Pat the salmon skin with paper towels until completely dry. Any moisture on the skin creates steam in the pan and prevents the skin from crisping. Score the skin lightly with 3 shallow cuts perpendicular to the fillet — this prevents the fillet from curling in the pan. Season the flesh only with fine salt. Do not season the skin — salt draws moisture to the surface.
- 2 Skin side down, cold pan start — or very hot:** Two valid techniques: cold pan start (place salmon skin-down in a cold non-stick pan, apply medium heat — the skin renders slowly and crisps without burning) or very hot pan (searing hot, skin down, 3 minutes, then flip once). The cold pan method is more forgiving and produces more consistently crispy skin. Cook skin-down for 80% of the cooking time. The flesh will turn opaque from the bottom up — flip when only the top 5mm remains translucent.
- 3 Teriyaki glaze — applied at the end:** Teriyaki glaze contains sugar (mirin, sake, white sugar) which burns at high heat. Add glaze only in the final 90 seconds — pour into the pan and let it bubble and reduce around the salmon. Tilt the pan and baste the fish with the thickening glaze using a spoon. The glaze should coat the fish with a glossy, lacquered finish. Remove from heat the moment it becomes glossy — 30 seconds too long produces bitter, burnt sugar.
- 4 Rest, then plate skin-up:** Rest the salmon on a rack for 90 seconds — never on a flat surface, which steams the skin soft again. Plate skin-side up so the guest sees the glazed, caramelised surface. The tsukemono pickled cucumber alongside cuts through the richness of the salmon and glaze — it is essential, not decorative. Steamed rice absorbs the excess glaze that runs from the fish.

Chef's Tip: Salmon teriyaki is your most popular dish with female guests aged 25–40. It photographs beautifully — the glossy glaze, golden skin, white rice — and is genuinely delicious. Keep your teriyaki glaze consistent by making large batches to the same recipe. The glaze is worth more than the fish — protect the recipe.

FISH GLUTEN (soy sauce) SOYA SESAME

Gyu Donburi — Simmered Beef Rice Bowl

Thinly sliced wagyu-style beef, dashi-soy broth, onion, onsen egg, pickled ginger · Sell: \$18.99

10 minMainFC 19%

INGREDIENTS (PER BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef (ribeye or chuck roll, very thin sliced)	120g	\$1.75
Onion (thinly sliced, simmered)	80g	\$0.12
Dashi-soy broth (dashi, soy, mirin, sake, sugar)	150ml	\$0.32
Steamed Japanese short-grain rice	200g cooked	\$0.25
Onsen tamago (slow-cooked egg 63°C)	1 egg	\$0.45
Beni shoga (pickled red ginger), spring onion, sesame	15g	\$0.11
Total cost per bowl		\$3.00
Cost per bowl		\$3.00
Sell price		\$18.99
Food cost %		15.8%
Contribution margin		\$15.99

- 1

Thin slicing is the technique: Beef for gyudon must be paper-thin — 2-3mm maximum. Partially freeze the beef (30 minutes in the freezer) before slicing to make thin cutting easier. Or buy pre-sliced shabu-shabu beef at Asian grocers. The thinness means the beef cooks in the broth in under 2 minutes — it should remain tender and absorb the dashi broth flavour completely. Thick-cut beef turns tough and misses the point of the dish.
- 2

Simmer onions until fully soft first: The onion is as important as the beef. Simmer sliced onion in the dashi-soy broth over medium heat for 8-10 minutes until completely translucent and softened. The onion sweetens and enriches the broth as it cooks. Then add the beef in a single layer over the onions — it cooks in 90 seconds. The intertwining of beef, onion, and broth-soaked rice is the entire experience of gyudon.
- 3

Onsen tamago — the signature topping: Onsen tamago is a slow-cooked egg held at 63°C / 145°F for 45 minutes. The result: fully set white, barely-set custard yolk — the opposite of a French soft-boiled egg. Use a sous vide immersion circulator for consistency. When broken over the gyudon, the yolk runs into the broth and rice, enriching the entire bowl. If no sous vide, use the ajitsuke tamago (marinated soft egg) from the ramen recipe as a substitute.
- 4

Beni shoga is mandatory: The pickled red ginger is not a garnish — it is a palate cleanser and flavour counterpoint that the Yoshinoya chain (Japan's most famous gyudon restaurant, 3,000+ locations) has served unchanged for 50 years. The acidity and piquancy of the beni shoga cuts through the fatty richness of the beef and broth. Without it, the bowl is incomplete. Non-negotiable.

Chef's Tip: Gyudon is one of Japan's great fast-comfort foods — it should come out within 8 minutes of ordering and deliver an intensely satisfying, soul-warming eating experience. Keep your dashi-soy broth base consistent. This dish at \$18.99 with a 15.8% food cost is exceptional margin for a main course.

GLUTEN (soy sauce)SOYAEGGS

Miso Ramen — White Miso Broth Noodle

Corn, butter, chashu, bamboo, bean sprouts, soft egg, sesame miso broth · Sell: \$16.99

12 min

Main

FC 20%

INGREDIENTS (PER BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken or pork bone broth base (batch)	350ml	\$0.88
Shiro miso (white miso, per bowl seasoning)	40g	\$0.32
Fresh ramen noodles (medium wavy)	130g	\$0.42
Chashu pork belly (shared batch)	60g	\$0.54
Corn kernels, butter pat, bean sprouts, bamboo	60g	\$0.28
Soft egg, nori, sesame, spring onion	1 egg + garnish	\$0.55
Total cost per bowl		\$2.99
Cost per bowl		\$2.99
Sell price		\$16.99
Food cost %		17.6%
Contribution margin		\$14.00

- 1**Never boil miso:** Miso contains live fermentation cultures and delicate volatile aromatic compounds that are destroyed by boiling. The broth base should be hot but not boiling when miso is added. Whisk miso paste into a small amount of warm broth first to create a smooth paste, then incorporate into the full broth. Taste and adjust — different miso varieties vary greatly in saltiness. Shiro (white) miso is the mildest and sweetest; aka (red) miso is saltier and more complex.
- 2**The Sapporo toppings are traditional:** Miso ramen originates from Hokkaido, Japan's northern island, where corn and butter are local staples added to the bowl for richness against the cold climate. A pat of cold butter placed on top of the hot ramen melts slowly during eating, enriching the broth progressively. This is not a modern trend — it is the traditional Sapporo miso ramen configuration. Own it fully.
- 3**Wavy noodles hold miso broth:** Use medium-width wavy noodles for miso ramen — their irregular surface traps the thick miso broth better than straight thin noodles. Cook in boiling unsalted water 90 seconds, strain, and place in the pre-warmed bowl. Pour the hot miso broth over immediately. The bowl should be as hot as possible — miso ramen loses quality rapidly as it cools. Serve immediately and never let it sit.
- 4**Corn and butter visual:** Place corn kernels in a neat mound on one side of the bowl and the butter pat on top of the corn — as it melts during service, it creates a visual pool of richness. This presentation signals generosity and warmth. The guest who photographs their miso ramen is advertising your restaurant. Make it worth photographing.

***Chef's Tip:** Miso ramen outsells tonkotsu 2:1 with female guests and is your most approachable ramen for first-timers. The corn and butter topping is genuinely delicious and visually distinctive. Share the batch broth base between both ramen styles — the tare (seasoning liquid) is what differentiates them, not the base. This is how real ramen shops operate.*

GLUTEN (noodles, miso, soy)

SOYA (miso)

EGGS

DAIRY (butter)

Ebi Tempura — Tiger Prawn Tempura

5 tiger prawns, light tempura batter, tentsuyu dipping sauce, daikon, matcha salt · Sell: \$18.99

10 min Main FC 21%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Tiger prawns (U15, peeled, deveined, tail on)	5 prawns / 120g	\$2.40
Tempura batter (ice-cold water, cake flour, egg)	60g batter	\$0.18
Tentsuyu sauce (batch — dashi, soy, mirin)	80ml	\$0.22
Grated daikon, grated ginger	30g	\$0.08
Matcha salt (finishing)	1g	\$0.06
Frying oil	—	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$3.00
Cost per serve		\$3.00
Sell price		\$18.99
Food cost %		15.8%
Contribution margin		\$15.99

- 1 **The cold batter is the technique:** Tempura batter must be ice-cold. Use ice-cold water — literally with ice cubes in the mixing bowl — and mix the batter minimally. Lumps are correct. Over-mixing develops gluten and creates a thick, doughy coating instead of the sheer, lacy, almost transparent crust that defines great tempura. Use cake flour (lower protein) or a 50/50 mix of plain flour and cornstarch. Mix batter fresh for each service — it deteriorates within 30 minutes.
- 2 **Straighten the prawns:** Score the underside of each prawn with 3–4 shallow cuts perpendicular to the length, then press gently to straighten. This prevents curling during frying — a straight prawn looks professional; a curled prawn looks like rushed street food. Pat prawns completely dry before dipping in batter — moisture creates explosive steam in the fryer and prevents the batter from adhering evenly.
- 3 **Fry at 180°C / 356°F, do not crowd:** Fry 2-3 prawns at a time maximum. Crowding drops the oil temperature below the critical threshold — the batter absorbs oil instead of repelling it, resulting in greasy, soft tempura. Each prawn takes 2–3 minutes. The batter should be pale gold with a sheer, lacy appearance — not dark brown, which indicates old oil or too-high temperature. Fresh oil produces the best tempura.
- 4 **Serve immediately, always:** Tempura has a window of approximately 3 minutes at peak quality. After that the batter begins to absorb steam from the hot prawn and soften. Serve directly from the fryer to the table. The tentsuyu dipping sauce (warm dashi, soy, mirin) with grated daikon stirred in is the traditional accompaniment — the daikon aids digestion of the fried food. Matcha salt on the side offers a modern contrast option.

***Chef's Tip:** Tempura is a discipline, not a technique. The Japanese spend years mastering it. Your batter temperature, oil temperature, prawn preparation, and service speed must all align simultaneously. The good news: when you nail it, it is unmistakably excellent. A perfectly made ebi tempura at an izakaya is one of the most satisfying things to eat on the planet.*

CRUSTACEANS (prawns) GLUTEN (flour) EGGS FISH (dashi)

Yaki Onigiri — Grilled Rice Ball

Two grilled soy-glazed rice balls, tuna mayo or pickled plum filling, miso soup · Sell: \$12.99

10 minMainFC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 2 RICE BALLS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Japanese short-grain rice (cooked, formed)	280g cooked	\$0.35
Tuna mayo filling (canned tuna, kewpie, soy)	30g	\$0.32
Soy glaze (brush, batch)	10ml	\$0.06
Nori wrap (half sheet each)	2 sheets	\$0.12
Miso soup (batch — dashi, miso, tofu, wakame)	200ml	\$0.18
Sesame seeds, spring onion	3g	\$0.04
Total cost per serve		\$1.07
Cost per serve		\$1.07
Sell price		\$12.99
Food cost %		8.2%
Contribution margin		\$11.92

- Form rice balls with wet hands:** Wet your hands and apply a small amount of salt to your palms. Take approximately 140g of freshly cooked rice — rice must be warm, not cold; cold rice does not compress properly. Form into a triangular shape by rotating the rice between cupped palms, applying firm but gentle pressure. The triangle should be compact enough to hold its shape but not so compressed that the rice becomes a dense block. Insert filling into the centre before closing.
- The yaki technique — grill until crusted:** Place formed onigiri on a hot flat griddle or grill pan brushed with a tiny amount of oil. Grill 3 minutes per side without moving — you are building a golden, slightly crispy rice crust. Brush with soy glaze in the final minute of each side — the soy caramelises and creates a dark, savoury lacquered exterior. The contrast of the crispy soy-glazed exterior and soft steamed rice interior is the point of yaki onigiri.
- Fillings determine repeat orders:** Offer at minimum two filling options: tuna mayo (umami, creamy, universally appealing) and umeboshi (pickled plum — sour, salty, traditional). Other options: salmon flake, mentaiko (spicy cod roe), or konbu (simmered kelp, vegetarian). Allow the guest to choose their filling at ordering — this small personalisation drives engagement and repeat visits. "Our most popular is tuna mayo, and the umeboshi is for purists — which are you?"
- Miso soup completes the set:** The miso soup served alongside is fundamental — not a garnish, not an add-on. It is the Japanese equivalent of bread and butter. Make dashi fresh daily (30 minutes, kombu + bonito), add miso off heat, add silken tofu cubes and dried wakame. Serve in a lacquer bowl with a lid if possible — the ritual of lifting the lid and experiencing the aroma is part of the experience.

Chef's Tip: Yaki onigiri at 8.2% food cost is your best-value main dish. It is also culturally authentic in a way that resonates deeply with Japanese food enthusiasts. The interactive filling choice and the visible grilling technique make it memorable. Batch-form rice balls during prep and grill to order — total service time under 8 minutes.

GLUTEN (soy glaze)SOYAFISH (tuna, dashi)EGGS (kewpie)SEAWEED (nori, wakame)

Saba Shioyaki — Salt-Grilled Mackerel

Whole mackerel fillet, coarse sea salt, grated daikon, soy, lemon, rice · Sell: \$18.99

12 minMainFC 20%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Atlantic mackerel fillet (skin on, butterflied)	200g	\$2.20
Coarse sea salt (generous coating, drawn moisture)	8g	\$0.02
Grated daikon (large mound)	60g	\$0.15
Steamed short-grain rice	180g cooked	\$0.22
Miso soup (shared batch)	200ml	\$0.18
Lemon wedge, soy sauce small dish, pickled vegetable	—	\$0.15
Total cost per serve		\$2.92
Cost per serve		\$2.92
Sell price		\$18.99
Food cost %		15.4%
Contribution margin		\$16.07

- Salt draws moisture and seasons deeply:** Salt the mackerel skin and flesh generously 30 minutes before grilling. The salt draws moisture from the fish via osmosis — pat dry after 30 minutes. This pre-salting concentrates the flavour of the fish, seasons it throughout (not just the surface), and dries the skin for crispier grilling. Never skip this step. Mackerel that is not pre-salted is flat in flavour and the skin will not crisp.
- Grill skin-side down, high heat:** Mackerel is a fatty fish that tolerates high heat well. Grill skin-side down under a preheated broiler or on a very hot grill at maximum heat. The skin should blister, char slightly at the edges, and crisp. The natural fat in the mackerel bastes the flesh from the inside. Cook 8-10 minutes skin-side only — the residual heat from the pan or grill finishes the flesh side in the final 2 minutes. Do not flip — the skin crisps fully only if left undisturbed.
- Shioyaki philosophy — respect the ingredient:** Shioyaki means "salt grill" — this is the purest expression of Japanese fish cookery. There is no sauce, no marinade, no complexity. The quality of the fish, the quality of the salt, and the skill of the grill are the entire dish. This dish communicates your kitchen's understanding of restraint and respect for ingredients more clearly than any technically elaborate dish. Many guests will judge the kitchen by this dish alone.
- The daikon ritsu — serve separately:** Grated daikon served alongside is a traditional digestive — mackerel is rich and fatty, and the peppery, slightly bitter daikon cuts through and cleanses the palate between bites. Squeeze lemon over the fish, mix a little grated daikon with soy sauce in the small dish, dip the fish lightly. This is the traditional way — teach it briefly to first-time guests. It creates engagement and cultural depth.

Chef's Tip: Mackerel is one of the most sustainable, affordable, and nutrient-dense fish on the market — yet it is undervalued in the US because it is under-ordered in mediocre restaurants. When grilled correctly, saba shioyaki is revelatory. The guest who orders this is a food person — treat it with full ceremony and they will become your most loyal advocate.

FISHGLUTEN (soy sauce)SOYA

Agedashi Nasu — Crispy Fried Eggplant

Japanese eggplant, light fry, dashi broth, sesame miso, spring onion · Sell: \$13.99

10 min Main · Vegetarian FC 12%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Japanese eggplant (long, thin, halved)	200g	\$0.60
Potato starch (light coating)	15g	\$0.04
Dashi broth with sesame miso (batch variation)	120ml	\$0.32
Spring onion, toasted sesame, shredded nori	8g	\$0.08
Frying oil	—	\$0.08
Steamed rice (side)	100g cooked	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$1.24
Cost per serve		\$1.24
Sell price		\$13.99
Food cost %		8.9%
Contribution margin		\$12.75

- 1

Japanese eggplant only: Japanese eggplant (nasu) is long, thin, with fewer seeds and much thinner skin than Italian or globe eggplant. The flesh is less bitter, absorbs less oil, and cooks more evenly. It is also more visually elegant. Score the skin side in a crosshatch pattern — this allows the hot dashi broth to absorb into the flesh after frying, creating the characteristic soft, yielding interior beneath the crispy exterior. Do not substitute globe eggplant.
- 2

Fry skin-side first at 180°C / 356°F : Coat in potato starch, fry skin-side down first for 2 minutes. The skin crisps and the crosshatch scores bloom open. Flip and fry flesh-side 2 minutes — the flesh should be golden and slightly yielding. The interior of the eggplant should be completely cooked through — undercooked eggplant is unpleasantly spongy. Test with a skewer: it should penetrate without resistance.
- 3

Sesame miso dashi variation: For agedashi nasu, enrich the dashi broth with a tablespoon of white sesame paste and a teaspoon of white miso — this creates a richer, more complex broth than the plain tentsuyu used for tofu. The sesame complements the eggplant's natural nuttiness and the miso adds fermented depth. Pour hot over the fried eggplant at the table. The steam and aroma arriving at the table is a dining moment.
- 4

Position as the vegetarian anchor: Agedashi nasu is your best vegetarian main — substantial, satisfying, visually beautiful, and at 8.9% food cost your best-margin option. Brief vegetarian guests proactively: "Our most popular vegetarian dish is the agedashi eggplant — it comes in a sesame miso dashi broth, table pour." This single sentence plants the order. The combination of dramatic tableside pour and gorgeous presentation earns social media posts every service.

***Chef's Tip:** Never be precious about vegetarian dishes — the best izakaya treats every item with equal craft regardless of whether it contains meat. A perfectly executed agedashi nasu will impress food-literate guests more than an average protein dish. Your vegetarian items are your silent ambassadors to a growing market segment.*

SOYA (miso, soy) GLUTEN (soy sauce) SESAME FISH (dashi – omit for vegan)

VEGAN ✓ (with kombu dashi)

Okonomiyaki — Osaka Savoury Pancake

Cabbage pancake, pork belly, okonomi sauce, kewpie, bonito, aonori · Sell: \$15.99

15 min

Main

FC 17%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Okonomiyaki batter (flour, dashi, egg, yam)	150g batter	\$0.42
Shredded napa cabbage	120g	\$0.18
Pork belly slices (thin, laid on top)	80g	\$0.72
Okonomi sauce (Otafuku brand or batch)	30ml	\$0.18
Kewpie mayo, aonori (green seaweed powder), bonito flakes, beni shoga	20g	\$0.22
Tenkasu (tempura bits, texture)	15g	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$1.82
Cost per serve		\$1.82
Sell price		\$15.99
Food cost %		11.4%
Contribution margin		\$14.17

- Nagaimo (mountain yam) is the secret:** Authentic Osaka okonomiyaki batter uses grated nagaimo (mountain yam) — it creates an extraordinarily light, airy, almost fluffy interior that is completely different from a dough-heavy pancake. If nagaimo is unavailable, substitute with grated apple (similar starch) or increase egg ratio. The texture of the final pancake depends on this ingredient more than any other. Do not skip or reduce it.
- Fold cabbage gently into batter:** Shredded cabbage should be coarse (not fine) — large pieces create pockets of steam inside the pancake that keep the interior light. Fold cabbage and tenkasu (tempura bits) gently into the batter — do not stir aggressively or the gluten develops and the pancake becomes tough. The batter should just barely hold the cabbage together, not encase it.
- Pork on top — then flip once:** Pour batter onto a greased flat griddle, shape into a 2cm-thick round. Lay thin pork belly slices across the top immediately. Cook 4-5 minutes until the edges are set and the bottom is golden. Flip once only — use two spatulas simultaneously for a clean flip. Cook pork-side down 3-4 minutes until pork is golden and caramelised. Flip back pork-side up to serve — the guest sees the caramelised pork on top.
- The decoration is as important as the cooking:** Apply okonomi sauce in zigzag lines, then kewpie mayo in opposite zigzag lines. This pattern is the visual signature of okonomiyaki globally — guests who have been to Osaka recognise it immediately. Scatter aonori generously, then bonito flakes — the heat of the pancake makes the bonito dance (odori). Beni shoga on the side. This entire decoration takes 20 seconds and transforms a pancake into a cultural statement.

Chef's Tip: Okonomiyaki is the most photogenic dish in Japanese comfort food. "Okonomiyaki" translates as "grilled as you like it" — the dish is infinitely customisable (seafood, cheese, mochi, extra toppings). Start with the classic pork belly version and offer 2 variations as specials. A table-side iron plate service (if your concept allows it) will make this dish a signature worth travelling for.

GLUTEN (batter, okonomi sauce) EGGS SOYA FISH (dashi, bonito, okonomi sauce)

3 DESSERTS

Matcha Tiramisu — Japanese Twist on Italian Classic

Ceremonial matcha, mascarpone, ladyfingers, white chocolate dusting · Sell: \$10.99

5 min (plating) Dessert FC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Mascarpone cream (batch)	80g	\$0.55
Ladyfingers (savoiardi, matcha-soaked)	40g	\$0.22
Ceremonial grade matcha powder	5g	\$0.35
White chocolate shavings	8g	\$0.16
Whipped cream (topping)	20g	\$0.12

Total cost per serve **\$1.40**

Cost per serve	\$1.40
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	12.7%
Contribution margin	\$9.59

- 1

Ceremonial grade matcha only: Culinary grade matcha is acceptable for baking into items where it is one of many flavours. For matcha tiramisu, the matcha is the entire flavour identity — ceremonial grade (vivid green, grassy, slightly sweet, complex umami) is non-negotiable. Culinary grade matcha is dull brown-green and bitter. The visual impact of a brilliant green dusting on white cream is the dish's signature. Source from Japanese suppliers — Uji, Kyoto origin is the benchmark.
- 2

Mascarpone cream method: Whip mascarpone with sugar until smooth, fold in lightly whipped heavy cream. Do not over- whip — the mascarpone should be light and airy, not stiff. Soak ladyfingers very briefly in cold matcha tea (ceremonial grade matcha dissolved in cold water) — they should be soaked through but not falling apart. The cold matcha soak (not espresso) is the Japanese adaptation.
- 3

Build in individual glasses or a tray: Individual glass service (wine glasses or rocks glasses) is visually superior and allows guests to see the distinct layers. Alternate matcha-soaked ladyfinger layer, mascarpone layer, repeat. Refrigerate minimum 4 hours — the flavours meld and the texture firms. Dust with matcha powder through a fine sieve immediately before service — this is the final moment where the dish is completed.
- 4

Serve with white chocolate and brief context: White chocolate shavings on top provide sweetness contrast to the grassy matcha bitterness. At service: "Our matcha tiramisu uses ceremonial grade Uji matcha — it's more complex and less bitter than what you'll find in most places. The white chocolate balances it." This single sentence sells the dish, educates the guest, and communicates your sourcing quality. Dessert orders increase significantly when front-of-house contextualises ingredients.

Chef's Tip: Matcha tiramisu is your most Instagram-worthy dessert — the vivid green against white cream photographs brilliantly. Build in large trays during prep, portion to glass to order. Consistent flavour, low service time, excellent margin. This dessert will drive social media content that markets your restaurant for free. Source good matcha and never cut corners on it.

GLUTEN (ladyfingers) EGGS DAIRY (mascarpone, cream)

Mochi Ice Cream — Handmade Rice Cake

Three-piece selection: matcha, black sesame, yuzu — served on ice · Sell: \$9.99

3 min (plating)

Dessert

FC 18%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 3 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Shiratamake (glutinous rice flour) mochi skin	60g per batch	\$0.28
Matcha ice cream (small scoop, 25g)	25g	\$0.42
Black sesame ice cream (small scoop)	25g	\$0.38
Yuzu sorbet (small scoop)	25g	\$0.44
Corn starch (prevent sticking during wrapping)	5g	\$0.01
Shiso leaf, gold leaf (optional presentation)	2g	\$0.27
Total cost per serve		\$1.80

Cost per serve

\$1.80

Sell price

\$9.99

Food cost %

18.0%

Contribution margin

\$8.19

- 1

Mochi skin technique: Mix shiratamake with sugar and water. Microwave in 1-minute bursts, stirring between each, until the mixture is translucent and sticky (3–4 minutes total). Alternatively steam over boiling water 20 minutes. The cooked mochi should be smooth, stretchy, and slightly glossy. Dust your work surface and hands generously with corn starch — cooked mochi is extremely sticky. Work quickly as it is easier to shape warm.
- 2

Pre-freeze ice cream scoops: Scoop small balls of each ice cream flavour onto a tray lined with cling film, freeze solid (minimum 2 hours). This allows fast wrapping — the ice cream must be frozen hard enough that the warm mochi skin does not melt it during wrapping. Work with one piece at a time, returning wrapped mochi to the freezer immediately. The entire production process is cold-chain critical.
- 3

Wrap and seal: Flatten a small piece of mochi dough, place frozen ice cream ball in the centre, gather edges and pinch tightly to seal. Roll lightly in cornstarch to prevent sticking. Freeze immediately — the mochi tightens around the ice cream as it freezes and becomes the characteristic smooth, firm exterior. Mochi ice cream can be stored frozen for up to 2 weeks — batch produce weekly.
- 4

Serve three flavours, explain each: Plate three mochi on a slate or wooden board with crushed ice beneath (presentation and temperature management). Briefly identify each flavour: "The green is ceremonial matcha, the dark one is roasted black sesame, the pale yellow is yuzu — Japanese citrus, like a floral lemon." This three-sentence education converts the dessert from "interesting" to "compelling" and virtually guarantees the guest will talk about it after the meal.

Chef's Tip: Mochi ice cream is the most universally loved Japanese dessert in the US market — it is sold at Costco, Trader Joe's, and every Asian grocery, which means your guests already have a reference point. Your handmade version must be visibly superior to the packaged version. The texture of freshly made mochi skin is categorically different — softer, chewier, more flavourful. Make it in-house and own this distinction.

DAIRY (ice cream)

GLUTEN-FREE ✓ (shiratamake is rice flour)

Check ice cream flavours for egg/nut content

Dorayaki — Honey Pancake with Red Bean

Two fluffy honey pancakes, sweet azuki bean paste, whipped cream · Sell: \$8.99

8 min

Dessert

FC 11%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Dorayaki batter (flour, eggs, sugar, honey, baking soda)	120g batter	\$0.28
Tsubu-an (chunky azuki red bean paste)	60g	\$0.22
Whipped cream (topping)	25g	\$0.15
Matcha powder (dusting)	1g	\$0.07
Honey (drizzle, finish)	5ml	\$0.06
Black sesame seeds (garnish)	1g	\$0.02
Total cost per serve		\$0.80
Cost per serve		\$0.80
Sell price		\$8.99
Food cost %		8.9%
Contribution margin		\$8.19

- 1

Batter resting is essential: Dorayaki batter must rest 30 minutes after mixing — this allows the baking soda to activate fully and the gluten to relax, producing the characteristic airy, honey-scented crumb. The batter should be thick — thicker than regular pancake batter. The honey in the batter creates a slightly golden colour and distinctive sweet aroma during cooking. Do not substitute maple syrup — honey creates a different Maillard reaction and flavour profile.
- 2

Cook on a flat griddle, low heat: The dorayaki pancake should cook slowly on a lightly oiled flat griddle over medium-low heat. Pour batter to form a circle approximately 10cm in diameter. Cook until bubbles form and the surface appears dry at the edges (3–4 minutes). Flip once with a smooth motion — the cooked side should be deep golden brown, uniform in colour. The underside takes 2 minutes. This slow cooking produces the soft, cakey, thick texture that distinguishes dorayaki from regular pancakes.
- 3

Azuki paste — make your own or source well: Tsubu-an (chunky) azuki bean paste is made by simmering azuki beans with sugar until soft and thickened. Homemade has better flavour and texture control; good commercial versions (Koshian or Tsubu-an from Japanese suppliers) are acceptable. The paste should be spreadable but not runny — it should hold its shape when the two pancakes are sandwiched. Avoid overly sweet commercial versions — they overwhelm the delicate honey pancake flavour.
- 4

Context sells this dish: Many US guests are unfamiliar with red bean paste desserts — they approach it with scepticism. Brief them before they order: "Dorayaki is the dessert Doraemon (the beloved Japanese cartoon) is famous for — it's two honey-scented pancakes with sweet azuki bean paste. The red bean is not heavy or earthy — it's light, nutty, mildly sweet. Most guests who were nervous about it become converts." This single context moment doubles the dessert attachment rate on this item.

***Chef's Tip:** Dorayaki at 8.9% food cost is your most profitable dessert per serving. It is also deeply culturally specific in a way that resonates with Japanese food enthusiasts and creates memorable conversations. Batch cook the pancakes during afternoon prep, fill to order. Service time under 3 minutes with pre-cooked pancakes. Dust matcha, drizzle honey, plate beautifully.*

GLUTEN (flour)

EGGS

DAIRY (cream)

Yuzu Panna Cotta — Citrus Cream Set Dessert

Set yuzu cream, yuzu curd, candied yuzu zest, sesame tuile · Sell: \$10.99

3 min (plating) Dessert FC 13%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Heavy cream (panna cotta base)	150ml	\$0.60
Yuzu juice (bottled, Japanese — not lemon)	25ml	\$0.38
Gelatin (setting agent)	3g	\$0.04
Sugar	20g	\$0.02
Yuzu curd (batch — eggs, yuzu, butter, sugar)	30g	\$0.22
Black sesame tuile (batch baked)	1 piece	\$0.08
Candied yuzu zest, micro herbs	3g	\$0.10

Total cost per serve \$1.44

Cost per serve	\$1.44
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	13.1%
Contribution margin	\$9.55

- 1 **Yuzu is irreplaceable:** Yuzu is a Japanese citrus fruit with a flavour unlike any Western citrus — simultaneously lemon, grapefruit, and mandarin with a distinct floral quality. Bottled yuzu juice from Japanese suppliers is available in the US and produces excellent results. Do not substitute lemon or lime — the flavour profile is completely different. The defining quality of good yuzu panna cotta is that the yuzu flavour is present but not overpowering — subtle citrus that lingers after the cream richness.
- 2 **Barely-set panna cotta — wobble is correct:** The panna cotta should wobble when shaken — barely set, not firm. Reduce gelatin quantity from standard recipes (1.5g per 100ml rather than 2g) for a trembling, almost liquid set. Too much gelatin produces a rubbery, thick-set panna cotta that is an unpleasant eating experience. The yuzu is added after the cream mixture cools slightly below 70°C / 158°F — heat destroys yuzu's delicate floral aromatics.
- 3 **Two-layer visual:** Set the plain cream panna cotta first in individual glasses or ramekins. Once set (minimum 3 hours), layer yuzu curd on top — the curd provides a bright, intensely flavoured contrast layer to the mild cream below. The visual cross-section when the dessert is broken into is yellow-white-cream, communicating the dual yuzu treatment to the guest. This two-layer approach elevates the dessert from simple to considered.
- 4 **Black sesame tuile for texture and drama:** The sesame tuile (thin, brittle, lacey biscuit made from sesame seeds bound with glucose syrup) provides the textural counterpoint to the soft cream. It also photographs brilliantly — the dark irregular tuile protruding from the pale cream is a striking visual. Batch produce tuiles weekly (they store well in an airtight container). The tuile also communicates that your kitchen bakes in-house — a quality signal guests notice.

***Chef's Tip:** Yuzu panna cotta is your most elegant dessert — it belongs in a fine-dining setting but works perfectly as an izakaya dessert closer. Its lightness after a rich meal (ramen, katsu, karaage) is the correct ending note. Batch produce the panna cottas daily, plate to order with curd, tuile, and candied zest. Service time under 2 minutes. This dish has the highest perceived value relative to cost on your entire menu.*

DAIRY (cream) EGGS (curd, tuile) SESAME GELATIN (not vegan)

Yuzu Highball — House Signature Cocktail

Japanese whisky, yuzu juice, sparkling water, yuzu zest · Sell: \$14.99

Cocktail

FC 16%

INGREDIENTS (PER GLASS)

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Japanese whisky (Suntory Toki or Nikka Days)	45ml	\$1.10
Yuzu juice (bottled)	20ml	\$0.30
Sparkling water (chilled)	120ml	\$0.08
Yuzu zest or thin wheel (garnish)	1 piece	\$0.12
Ice (large clear cube)	1 cube	\$0.05

Total cost per glass

\$1.65

Cost per glass

\$1.65

Sell price

\$14.99

Food cost %

11.0%

Contribution margin

\$13.34

- 1 Build in a tall glass over one large clear ice cube. Pour whisky first, then yuzu juice, top with chilled sparkling water. Do not stir aggressively — gentle stir only to combine, preserving carbonation. Garnish with a thin yuzu wheel or expressed zest twist. The large ice cube melts slowly, maintaining dilution control throughout the drink.
- 2 The highball is Japan's most consumed cocktail — the izakaya highball culture is as embedded in Japanese drinking culture as the pint glass is in British pub culture. Serve it in a branded tall glass if possible. The drama of a chilled, perfectly clear glass arriving with a large ice cube and yuzu garnish communicates the quality of your drinks programme immediately.
- 3 Upsell the whisky selection: "We use Suntory Toki for the house highball — lighter, citrusy. For \$4 more we can do it with Nikka From The Barrel — richer, more complex. Which do you prefer?" This conversation increases average spend and demonstrates genuine drinks knowledge. Guests who know Japanese whisky will respect you for offering the upgrade.

ALCOHOL

Contains Japanese whisky — check allergen info with distillery if required

Sake — Hot or Cold Service

Junmai or nigori sake, 180ml tokkuri (carafe) service · Sell: \$12.99

Japanese Wine FC 22%

PER TOKKURI SERVICE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Junmai sake (dry, versatile food pairing)	180ml	\$2.20
Tokkuri (ceramic carafe) + ochoko (cups) rental	1 set	\$0.40
Heating (for hot sake — kanzake)	—	\$0.05

Total cost per serve **\$2.65**

Cost per serve	\$2.65
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	20.4%
Contribution margin	\$10.34

- 1 Offer the temperature choice proactively: "Would you like it hot or cold? Hot sake — we warm it to 45°C — brings out the umami and warms you through. Cold sake is crisper, more delicate. We recommend hot with the ramen and cold with the sashimi." The recommendation framework positions your staff as knowledgeable and drives the guest toward the most satisfying pairing experience.
- 2 Hot sake service: Warm in a water bath at 45°C / 113°F — do not microwave, which creates hot spots and diminishes flavour. Pour into the tokkuri and serve with two ochoko cups. The ritual of pouring for each other is a Japanese social custom — brief guests: "It's traditional in Japan to pour sake for others at the table — not for yourself." This cultural moment elevates the experience significantly.
- 3 Offer a nigori (cloudy sake) alternative for guests who want something more distinctive. Nigori is unfiltered — it has a milky appearance, slightly sweet, creamy flavour with a gentle funk. It pairs magnificently with spicy dishes and is visually unique. Position it as: "If you want something more adventurous — our nigori is cloudy, a little sweet, really pairs well with the karaage."

ALCOHOL GLUTEN-FREE ✓ (pure rice sake)

Matcha Latte — Hot or Iced

Ceremonial matcha, steamed oat milk, honey option · Sell: \$7.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 15%

PER SERVE

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Ceremonial matcha powder	4g	\$0.28
Hot water (for matcha paste, 70°C)	30ml	\$0.00
Oat milk (steamed or cold)	200ml	\$0.52
Honey (optional sweetener)	8g	\$0.08
Matcha dusting (finish)	0.5g	\$0.04

Total cost per serve \$0.92

Cost per serve	\$0.92
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	11.5%
Contribution margin	\$7.07

- 1

Whisk matcha powder with a small amount of water at 70°C / 158°F — never boiling water, which makes matcha bitter. Use a bamboo chasen (whisk) or electric milk frother to create a smooth, lump-free paste with a light foam cap. This paste is the base of the latte.
- 2

Steam oat milk to 65°C for hot service — oat milk froths well and has a neutral sweetness that complements matcha without overpowering it. Pour over the matcha paste and dust the surface with a fine sieve of matcha powder. For iced: pour cold oat milk over the matcha paste with ice — do not blend, allow the layers to remain distinct for visual impact.
- 3

Non-alcoholic guests and daytime diners represent a significant revenue opportunity. A \$7.99 matcha latte at 11.5% food cost over 6 covers per table per service session adds meaningful revenue. Promote proactively as the signature non-alcoholic option for the table alongside the food order.

DAIRY-FREE ✓ (oat milk) GLUTEN-FREE ✓ VEGAN ✓

Calpico Soda — Japanese Soft Drink

Original Calpico concentrate, sparkling water, lime, shiso · Sell: \$5.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 10%

PER SERVE

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Calpico concentrate (Calpis brand)	60ml	\$0.28
Sparkling water	150ml	\$0.10
Fresh lime juice	10ml	\$0.06
Shiso leaf (garnish)	1 leaf	\$0.04
Ice	—	\$0.02

Total cost per serve **\$0.50**

Cost per serve	\$0.50
Sell price	\$5.99
Food cost %	8.3%
Contribution margin	\$5.49

- Calpico (Calpis) is a fermented milk-based soft drink — milky, slightly tangy, mildly sweet, and utterly distinct from any Western soft drink. It is Japan's most nostalgic commercial beverage. Pour concentrate over ice, top with sparkling water, squeeze lime, garnish with shiso. The shiso adds a fresh herbal note that elevates it from a convenience store drink to a considered izakaya offering.
- At \$5.99 with \$0.50 cost this is your highest-margin drinks item. It also serves as a cultural gateway for guests — "This is Calpico — it's a Japanese classic, a bit like a lighter, fermented lemonade. Very refreshing with the fried food." Guests who try it are almost universally delighted and will order it again on every visit.

DAIRY (Calpico contains milk) GLUTEN-FREE ✓

Shochu Soda — Spirit Highball

Sweet potato shochu, sparkling water, lemon, cucumber · Sell: \$11.99

Cocktail FC 17%

PER GLASS

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Ichiko or Satsuma Musume imo-shochu	60ml	\$1.20
Sparkling water	120ml	\$0.08
Fresh lemon juice	15ml	\$0.08
Cucumber ribbon (garnish)	1 ribbon	\$0.04
Ice	—	\$0.05

Total cost per glass \$1.45

Cost per glass	\$1.45
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	12.1%
Contribution margin	\$10.54

- 1 Shochu is a Japanese spirit distilled from sweet potato (imo), barley (mugi), or rice (kome) — lower ABV than whisky (25%), cleaner than vodka, with a subtle earthy sweetness. Sweet potato shochu has the most character and pairs best with food. Build in a tall glass over ice: shochu first, squeeze of lemon, top sparkling water, cucumber ribbon garnish.
- 2 Position shochu to guests as "Japan's answer to vodka — same versatility, more depth, about half the alcohol so you can drink more of it over dinner." This positioning is accurate and removes hesitation from guests unfamiliar with the spirit. The imo-shochu's slight earthiness pairs brilliantly with yakitori, karaage, and the richer dishes on the menu.

ALCOHOL GLUTEN-FREE ✓ (imo shochu is sweet potato)

Japanese Beer — Asahi Super Dry Draft

Asahi Super Dry or Sapporo, draught or bottle · Sell: \$8.99

Beer FC 18%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Asahi Super Dry (330ml bottle or 400ml draught)	1 serve	\$1.40
Branded glass (if draught)	—	\$0.22
Total cost per serve		\$1.62
Cost per serve		\$1.62
Sell price		\$8.99
Food cost %		18.0%
Contribution margin		\$7.37

- Asahi Super Dry is the global benchmark for Japanese beer — ultra-dry, highly carbonated, light-bodied. It was designed specifically to pair with food, not to be the centre of attention. The high carbonation cuts through fried and fatty dishes (karaage, tonkotsu ramen, katsu) better than any craft beer. Sapporo is a slightly maltier alternative for guests who prefer more flavour.
- The best beer moment in an izakaya is the first pour — the creamy foam head, the crystal-clear golden body, the fine carbonation. If pouring draught, angle the glass at 45°, pour to two-thirds, allow the foam to build, then straighten the glass and top. The foam should be dense and creamy — 1cm depth. This technique is how it is poured in every izakaya in Japan. Teach it to all bar staff.

ALCOHOL GLUTEN (barley)

Hojicha Cold Brew — Roasted Green Tea

Cold-brewed roasted hojicha, served long with ice · Sell: \$5.99

Non-Alcoholic

FC 8%

PER GLASS

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Hojicha leaves (cold brewed 8hr, 10g per 500ml)	200ml brew	\$0.30
Simple syrup (optional, on request)	10ml	\$0.04
Ice	—	\$0.02
Lemon wheel (optional garnish)	1 slice	\$0.04
Total cost per glass		\$0.40
Cost per glass		\$0.40
Sell price		\$5.99
Food cost %		6.7%
Contribution margin		\$5.59

- 1 Hojicha is green tea that has been roasted over charcoal — the roasting process converts the grassy, vegetal notes of green tea into warm, toasty, caramel-like flavours. Low in caffeine (the roasting reduces caffeine significantly). Cold brew: steep hojicha leaves in cold water for 8 hours, strain, serve chilled over ice. The cold brew method produces a smooth, mellow flavour without any bitterness.
- 2 Hojicha cold brew at 6.7% food cost is your best-margin non-alcoholic drink. Brief it as: "It's roasted green tea — lower caffeine, caramel and toasty notes, nothing like the grassy green teas you might know. Perfect food pairing with the fried items." This description converts most guests who are unfamiliar. A pitcher of cold brew on the table sells itself visually — consider offering a 500ml pitcher at \$12.99 for the table.

GLUTEN-FREE ✓

VEGAN ✓

CAFFEINE: low

Ume Spritz — Japanese Plum Wine Cocktail

Choya umeshu, prosecco, soda, pickled plum garnish · Sell: \$12.99

Cocktail FC 18%

PER GLASS

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Choya Umeshu (plum wine)	60ml	\$1.10
Prosecco (dry)	60ml	\$0.65
Sparkling water	60ml	\$0.05
Pickled ume plum (from Choya bottle, garnish)	1	\$0.15
Ice	—	\$0.05

Total cost per glass \$2.00

Cost per glass	\$2.00
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	15.4%
Contribution margin	\$10.99

- 1

Umeshu (Japanese plum wine) is made by steeping green ume plums in shochu with sugar. Choya is the market leader — sweet, stone-fruit forward, gently alcoholic. Build the spritz over ice in a wine glass: umeshu, prosecco, sparkling water in equal thirds. Garnish with the preserved ume plum from the Choya bottle — it is sweet, slightly salty, intensely flavoured and adds a savoury note that makes the drink more complex.
- 2

The ume spritz is your most approachable cocktail for guests new to Japanese drinks — it is sweet, familiar in format (spritz), beautiful (rose-amber colour), and the ume garnish is a conversation piece. Best-seller among female guests at weekend lunches. Position as: "It's a Japanese take on the Aperol spritz — plum wine base, very smooth and refreshing." The Aperol spritz reference anchors it immediately for Western guests.

ALCOHOL GLUTEN-FREE ✓

5 SERVICE TRAINING MODULE

Izakaya Service Philosophy: An izakaya is not a restaurant — it is a drinking establishment that happens to serve excellent food. The pace is unhurried. Guests arrive in groups, order progressively throughout the evening, drink consistently, and leave when they are ready. Your job is not to turn the table — it is to make the table want to stay. Revenue comes from depth of spending per guest, not speed of turnover.

// OPENING WELCOME

"Irasshaimase — welcome. My name is [name], I'll be taking care of you tonight. Our kitchen is Japanese izakaya style — everything is designed to share and graze. The best approach is to start with a round of small plates and drinks, then build from there as the evening goes. Can I start you with drinks while you look over the food?"

Why: Irasshaimase is the universal Japanese welcome — guests who know Japanese culture will feel the authenticity; guests who don't will be intrigued and ask about it. The ordering framework (share and graze) sets expectations and prevents the common mistake of guests ordering everything at once and being overwhelmed.

// DRINKS KNOWLEDGE DEMONSTRATION

"For drinks — can I ask what you usually like? We have a full sake selection, Japanese whisky highballs, and some spirits you might not have tried. If you're beer people, we do Asahi Super Dry on draught — it's designed specifically to pair with food, very clean. If you want something lighter, our hojicha cold brew is our most popular non-alcoholic. What sounds good?"

Why: Asking what they usually like is more productive than listing options. It makes the guest feel understood and allows the server to make a targeted recommendation. Never ask "do you want drinks?" — always make the affirmative assumption and guide to a choice.

// KARAAGE SELL SCRIPT

"For starters — our karaage is double-fried chicken thigh with Kewpie mayo. It's what we're probably most known for. If you've never had it, it's the best fried chicken you'll try anywhere — the double-fry technique we use gives it a crunch that regular fried chicken doesn't have. It also pairs perfectly with the highball or cold beer."

Why: The best-known dish is the entry point. The double-fry detail sounds technical but is delivered as a food story — it signals kitchen craft. The beer pairing recommendation drives a drinks order simultaneously with the food order.

// MID-MEAL CHECK-IN

"How is everything landing? Can I get you another round of drinks? — and if you're still hungry, the yakitori is worth going again on, or the okonomiyaki is good to share at the end of the meal while you finish your drinks."

Why: This check-in serves three functions: it opens a beverage reorder, it extends the food order with specific recommendations (not vague "do you want more food"), and it communicates that staying longer is welcome. The izakaya model requires guests to feel unhurried.

// DESSERT ATTACHMENT SCRIPT

"For dessert — our matcha tiramisu is made with ceremonial grade Uji matcha and it's genuinely one of the things people come back for. We also do mochi ice cream in three flavours — matcha, black sesame, yuzu. Most tables end up doing both and sharing. Can I bring them?"

Why: "Most tables end up doing both" is a social proof statement that normalises ordering both desserts and removes individual hesitation. The affirmative close ("Can I bring them?") assumes yes rather than asking if they want any dessert — significantly higher attachment rate.

6

WEEKLY PREP SCHEDULE

TASK	FREQUENCY	TIME REQUIRED	NOTES
Tonkotsu broth batch (large)	Mon + Thu	12-18 hours (overnight)	Start Sunday/Wednesday night; cool in stock pots
Chashu pork belly braise	Tue + Fri	3 hours	Cool and slice cold; store in braising liquid
Ajitsuke tamago (marinated eggs)	Daily	30 min	6.5-min boil, peel, marinate; 48hr max in brine
Gyoza filling + forming	Mon + Thu	2 hours	Freeze on trays; cook from frozen to order
Japanese curry batch	Mon + Thu	1.5 hours	Improves overnight; refrigerate; reheat per service
Tare glaze (yakitori + teriyaki)	Weekly top-up	20 min	Never discard tare — add fresh to aged batch
Ponzu sauce batch	Weekly	20 min	Improves with time; make large batch
Matcha tiramisu (tray)	Daily	45 min	Refrigerate minimum 4 hours before service

Mochi ice cream production	Weekly	1.5 hours	Freeze on trays; store in airtight containers
Dorayaki pancakes (batch)	Daily	30 min	Cook and store; fill and plate to order
Yuzu panna cotta (batch)	Daily	20 min + 4hr set	Make AM for PM service
Hojicha cold brew	Daily	5 min active (8hr passive)	Start previous night for next-day service
Dashi base (kombu + bonito)	Daily	30 min	Use for miso soup, agedashi, tsuyu — single batch serves all
Tsukemono pickles batch	Twice weekly	30 min	Quick-pickle cucumber, daikon; refrigerate

7 CUSTOMER RETENTION SYSTEM

// THE IZAKAYA RETURN DRIVER

The izakaya's greatest asset is its format — it is not a special-occasion restaurant. It is a regular spot. The rhythm of ordering rounds, sharing plates, and lingering over drinks is designed for habitual return. Your job is to create regulars, not one-time customers. Every operational decision should be evaluated against: "Does this make someone want to come back next week?"

// THE SEASONAL ROTATION SIGNAL

"We rotate some specials seasonally — next month we're adding [dish]. If you want to be notified, we have a text list — just give your number at the front desk."

Why: The text/SMS list is your most powerful direct marketing channel. 98% SMS open rate vs 20% email. Seasonal rotation signals that there is always something new to discover — creates a reason to return beyond what they already know they love.

// THE REGULARS RECOGNITION PROTOCOL

When a guest returns a second time: "Welcome back — good to see you again. Are you in a karaage mood tonight or do you want to try some different things?" When they return a third time: remember their usual drink and have it waiting or bring it without being asked.

Why: Being remembered is the most powerful retention tool in hospitality. It converts guests into advocates. One remembered regular tells five people about the experience. The three-visit protocol (remember face, remember order, anticipate order) is achievable by trained staff at any volume level.

8 P&L MODEL — 80-SEAT IZAKAYA, US MARKET 2025

REVENUE STREAM	AVG WEEKLY COVERS	AVG SPEND	WEEKLY REVENUE
Dinner service (Tue–Thu)	180 covers	\$52	\$9,360
Dinner service (Fri–Sat)	240 covers	\$58	\$13,920
Lunch service (Sat–Sun)	120 covers	\$38	\$4,560
Total Weekly Revenue	540 covers	\$51 avg	\$27,840

COST CATEGORY	% OF REVENUE	WEEKLY AMOUNT	NOTES
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Food & beverage cost	22%	\$6,125	Blended food + drinks CoGS
Labour (kitchen + FOH)	28%	\$7,795	US wage market rate
Rent (prime location)	10%	\$2,784	Budget \$11,136/month
Utilities + supplies	5%	\$1,392	Gas, electricity, POS, packaging
Marketing + licences	3%	\$835	Social, liquor licence amortised
Miscellaneous + contingency	2%	\$557	Repairs, waste, variance
Total Operating Costs	70%	\$19,488	
Net Operating Profit	30%	\$8,352/week	~\$434,304/year

9 ALLERGEN SUMMARY TABLE

DISH	GLUTEN	DAIRY	EGGS	FISH	SHELLFISH	SOYA	SESAME	NUTS
Edamame	—	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Gyoza	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Agedashi Tofu	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	—	—
Yakitori	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	—	—
Karaage	✓	—	✓	—	—	✓	—	—
Tataki Beef	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	✓	—
Tonkotsu Ramen	✓	—	✓	—	—	✓	—	—
Chicken Katsu Curry	✓	✓	✓	—	—	✓	—	—
Salmon Teriyaki	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	✓	—
Gyu Donburi	✓	—	✓	—	—	✓	—	—
Miso Ramen	✓	✓	✓	—	—	✓	—	—
Ebi Tempura	✓	—	✓	✓	✓	—	—	—
Yaki Onigiri	✓	—	✓	✓	—	✓	—	—
Saba Shioyaki	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	—	—
Agedashi Nasu	✓	—	—	✓*	—	✓	✓	—
Okonomiyaki	✓	—	✓	✓	—	✓	—	—
Matcha Tiramisu	✓	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	—
Mochi Ice Cream	—	✓	✓*	—	—	—	—	—
Dorayaki	✓	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	—
Yuzu Panna Cotta	—	✓	✓	—	—	—	✓	—

✓* = depends on specific product batch. Always verify with suppliers. Cross-contamination risk exists in shared kitchen environments. Always advise guests with severe allergies to inform staff.

"The greatest kitchens I have visited in Japan shared one quality that no guide or award can fully capture: they were operated by people who had decided, at some point, that they would do one thing and do it without compromise for the rest of their lives. The yakitori master who has been tending his charcoal grill for thirty years is not bored — he is still discovering. The ramen chef who adjusted his tare recipe last Tuesday is not obsessing — he is refining. Japanese cuisine, at its core, teaches us that mastery is not a destination. It is a daily practice of showing up, paying attention, and caring about the work. This guide will give you the recipes, the costs, the scripts, and the systems. The shokunin spirit — the craftsman's soul — is something you build one service at a time."

Build something worth returning to. 居酒屋 — Izakaya.